



refugee camps, often intervening at personal risk to stop looting and mayhem. Before Independence, Nehru had a naïve assumption that communal antagonism would come to an end once the British had departed. With the killing and mass migration of Partition, he had the cruelest awakening imaginable, to the dangers facing his own vision of his country. Unless free India could be united around a modern, democratic, socialist ideal, his life's work would be a failure.

Until the 19th century, the idea of India was vague—although it became politically necessary to create it in hindsight, and invoke the emperor

Ashoka with his pillar and wheel. In previous times, a person owed loyalty to little beyond an extended family, a place, or perhaps a profession. Today, when national identity is so strong, it is easy to forget the extent to which Indianness is a recent creation. Once the British had conquered territory and painted the map red, it became easier to see what needed to be opposed. A common sense of pride and purpose grew, with khadi as the first truly pan-Indian symbol. The freedom movement evicted the alien rulers easily compared to the long and bloody battles for nationhood elsewhere in the world, giving an optimistic momentum that inspired the struggles

**SOCIALIST
VISION: A
popular art
illustration
showing the
Nehruvian
ideal of unity**